

NORMALIZATION GAUNTLET

Written for
Featherweight

Original test fixture

8/3/2026
Local fixture – not for production

INT. ARCHIVE - NIGHT

Rain combs the black windows of a nearly empty municipal archive. Rows of steel shelves vanish into the dark, each one tagged with a different year.

MARA VALE, an investigator with a careful eye and no patience left, sets a battered document case beneath the only working lamp.

The *silver* key slides into the lock. The *intercontinental* seal stamped across the case remains one word despite the change in emphasis.

A **bold warning**, an *italic whisper*, and an underlined instruction occupy three separate cards. A final card reads Permanently.

The typewritten evidence includes "curly quotation marks," Mara's apostrophe, an em dash — exactly here — and an ellipsis... exactly there.

The office file confirms a final affinity flourish. A deliberately encoded ligature follows for comparison: fi and fl.

A courier has written counter-revolutionary in permanent ink. The source hyphen belongs to the word and must survive.

At the center of the page, a monitor reads NORMALIZATION FIXTURE. This occurrence belongs to the scene, not the running header.

Mara writes FEATHERWEIGHT TEST on an evidence envelope. This occurrence belongs to the scene, not the running footer.

She stamps REVIEW COPY across a loose photograph. This occurrence belongs to the scene, not the watermark.

The blue lantern remains lit.

NOAH REED enters carrying two coffee cups and a stack of folders tall enough to hide his face.

NOAH
Tell me the lock opened.

MARA
The lock opened.

NOAH
And the case?

MARA
(studying the cards)
The case is making editorial
choices.

Noah places one cup beside a ruler, leaving a precise gap
between them.

NOAH
That sounds judgmental.

MARA
It used bold type.

NOAH
Very judgmental.

The rain intensifies. Nothing else moves.

INT. ARCHIVE - LATER

The case now covers an entire table. Mara works at the left
edge while Noah works at the right, their notes occupying
distinct columns on the same horizontal plane.

MARA
Read the left column.

NOAH
Read the right column.

MARA
Column one remains
separate.

NOAH
Column two remains
separate.

They exchange pages without crossing the center of the table.

MARA
Now read them together.

NOAH
That would destroy the evidence.

MARA
Good answer.

On a lower shelf, a label repeats a phrase found upstairs.

The blue lantern remains lit.

Noah uncaps a pen.

NOAH
I have three versions of the same
account. One is clean, one has
production markings, and one was

NOAH
photocopied until every letter grew
a shadow.

MARA
We compare the clean account with
the marked account. The words should
agree even when the pages do not.

NOAH
And the shadows?

MARA
Evidence, until we can prove they
are duplicates.

Noah underlines the phrase *until we can prove it* without
touching the punctuation.

A narrow receipt contains the word *microarchitecture* beside
the phrase source-preserving. Neither style boundary
creates a new word.

The archive clock advances by one minute.

INT. CALIBRATION ROOM - PRE-DAWN

White tape divides the floor into measured lanes. Mara places
the document case at the starting mark.

The first calibration lamp turns green.

The second calibration lamp turns green.

The third calibration lamp turns green.

The fourth calibration lamp flickers, then turns green.

Noah measures the left margin and records it without
interpretation.

Mara measures the right margin and records it without
interpretation.

A printer advances one sheet and stops.

A second sheet settles beneath the first.

A third sheet lands slightly crooked but remains readable.

The blue lantern remains lit.

Mara compares the baseline of two adjacent fragments.

Noah compares the horizontal gap between them.

Neither of them guesses what kind of screenplay element the fragments will become.

The ventilation system clicks on.

The printer advances another sheet.

The room grows brighter by degrees.

Mara circles an intact source apostrophe.

Noah boxes an intact source hyphen.

Mara draws a line around two overlapping impressions without erasing either one.

Noah turns to the final page of the account.

NOAH

I am going to read this continuously so the speech begins late on one page and has no choice but to continue onto the next. First, the original words remain the authority. Second, a physical page boundary remains useful evidence, but it does not become a new thought merely because the printer ran out of room. Third, a continuation marker added by the exporter is not part of what I said. Fourth, my name repeated at the top of the next page is not a second speaker entering the room. Fifth, an inferred space must be distinguishable from a space that appeared in the source. Sixth, two glyphs occupying the same place may be duplicates, but neither should disappear without a recorded reason. Seventh, a wrapped sentence remains one sentence even when its physical lines begin at slightly different horizontal positions. Eighth, punctuation stays attached to the words it punctuates. Ninth, a ligature may represent more than one character without becoming more than one idea. Tenth, recurring headers and footers are detected from the document as a whole, not from a list of phrases somebody happened to anticipate. Eleventh, the words NORMALIZATION FIXTURE remain legitimate when they occur here in my dialogue, even if the same words

NOAH

appear at the top of every page. Twelfth, the words FEATHERWEIGHT TEST remain legitimate when they occur here in my dialogue, even if the same words appear at the bottom of every page. Thirteenth, the words REVIEW COPY remain legitimate when they occur here in my dialogue, even if the same words appear diagonally behind every page. Fourteenth, the clean export and the marked export should recover the same ordered content. Fifteenth, their coordinates and page provenance may differ, and that difference must remain available for inspection. Sixteenth, uncertain cleanup must preserve the text and produce a diagnostic instead of silently deleting it. Seventeenth, none of this tells us whether I am dialogue, action, a parenthetical, or a character cue; that judgment belongs to the recognizer that comes later. Eighteenth, dual columns must remain distinct until that recognizer has enough evidence to understand them. Nineteenth, existing spaces are never trimmed merely because a neighboring run begins nearby. Twentieth, missing spaces are never invented merely because two runs happen to share a baseline. Twenty-first, geometry supplies evidence rather than certainty. Twenty-second, the document supplies patterns rather than fixed margins. Twenty-third, every transformation must be explainable. Twenty-fourth, every retained character must remain traceable. Twenty-fifth, every suppressed artifact must remain auditable. And finally, when this speech reaches the next page, the synthetic words around it must not become part of the account itself.

Mara waits until the printer stops.

MARA

That was comprehensive.

NOAH

I had time to prepare.

EXT. ARCHIVE ROOF - DAWN

The storm has passed. Water beads along the railing, turning the skyline into a row of tiny lenses.

Mara carries the clean account. Noah carries the marked account.

The blue lantern remains lit in the window below, repeated once more as legitimate story content and nowhere near a page edge.

MARA

Same words?

NOAH

Same account. Different evidence.

MARA

Then it is ready for recognition.

They close the document case.

THE END